

Balasubramanyam Pattath

Geneva, Switzerland | balupattath04@gmail.com | bpattath.github.io | github.com/bpattath | [LinkedIn](#)

Experience

Global Development Network (GDN), Economist 2023–present
Research Lead, [DPI Inclusivity Measurement Programme](#) (2026–present); Programme Manager (2024–2025)

- **Grantmaking.** Co-designed the call for proposals for national research teams under the Digital Public Infrastructure (DPI) Inclusivity Measurement Programme, funded by [Co-Develop](#). The call drew 90 applications from more than 40 countries. Scored the shortlist and selected five teams (Chile, Sierra Leone, Ghana, Bangladesh, Indonesia) for research grants of up to USD 55,000 each. Review their sampling designs, instruments and budgets as the work proceeds.
- As Programme Manager, managed research grants to national teams in Bangladesh, Ethiopia and Benin for GDN's pilot on the socioeconomic impact of DPI, and wrote the [synthesis report](#) (2025).
- **Fundraising.** Wrote two funded proposals: USD 1.3 million from the Gates Foundation (Building the Economics of Open Transaction Networks) and USD 0.7 million from Co-Develop (Inclusivity of DPI).
- **Research.** Designed the common-core household survey on DPI inclusion now being fielded in five low- and middle-income countries. Co-author of working papers on artificial intelligence, production bottlenecks and DPI (listed below). Lead a parallel track on using system-generated operational data to locate where users drop out of digital services.
- **Policy engagement.** Panelist at the WSIS Forum (ITU, 2026); contributor to the ITU working group on DPI for cities; prepared a publication for the G20 presidency handover from India to Brazil.

Independent consulting, Economist 2025–present

- **NutGraph / [Land Conflict Watch](#), India** (2026–present). Developing a methodology and a reusable calculator that estimates the financial cost to developers of land-conflict delays in utility-scale solar and wind projects, applied to 42 documented conflicts. The model reports floor, central and high estimates and draws missing parameters from a sourced benchmark library.
- **Nayaneethi Policy Collective, Kerala** (2025–present). Estimated the social return on investment of [TinkerHub Foundation's](#) technology and coding programmes for college students in Kerala, using a psychometric and skills measurement survey. Designed samples and costed budgets for statewide studies of senior citizens (for KIMSHEALTH) and of higher education.
- **Nayaneethi: First Signal and LLM Health Safety Evals** (2026). Scoping First Signal, a climate and health early-warning platform at concept stage, including a prior-art review of early-warning systems. Designed an open benchmark of large language model reliability for health decision support in low-resource settings (grounding, Malayalam and code-switched safety, honesty under degraded surveillance data) and ran a [12-item pilot](#) across six models. github.com/bpattath/llm-health-safety-evals

World Bank Group, Consultant Economist 2022–2023

- Built two toolkits that automate cleaning and analysis of firm census and Enterprise Survey data. Prepared [policy briefs](#) and [reports](#) for the Social Protection, Poverty, and Finance, Competitiveness and Innovation global practices.

Indian School of Business, Economics Research Associate 2018–2020

- Sole research associate on a pilot and randomised controlled trial in Bihar on age-appropriate vaccination of infants. Wrote two funded proposals (J-PAL Cash Transfers for Child Health Initiative; International Growth Centre).
- Analysed DLHS, DHS, HMIS and IHDS data; built a dataset on community health workers in India.

Other research roles. NORRAG, innovative finance for education (2023–2024); Swiss National Science Foundation [Ambizione project](#) with T. Singh (2025–present); research assistant to L. Vandewalle (2022–2023) and to J.-L. Arcand and S. Irudaya Rajan (2021–2023), Geneva Graduate Institute.

Research on AI and development

- “These Aren’t the Droids You’re Looking For: Endogenous AI, O-Rings, and Bottleneck Reallocation” (with Jean-Louis Arcand), working paper, September 2026. [Draft](#). Presented at a SANEM public lecture, Dhaka, August 2026; coverage in [The Business Standard](#) and [The Daily Star](#).
- “Rails, Adoption, and Intelligence: Coordinating Artificial Intelligence and Digital Public Infrastructure for Development” (with Jean-Louis Arcand), working paper, September 2026.

Education and training

PhD in Economics , Geneva Graduate Institute, <i>summa cum laude</i>	2026
Thesis: <i>Three Essays in Development Economics</i> . Committee: Jean-Louis Arcand (supervisor), Martina Viarengo, Vijayendra Rao (World Bank, external examiner).	
Doctoral coursework , Fellow Programme in Management, Indian School of Business	2018–2020
MA in Development Studies , Geneva Graduate Institute	2018
BA (Hons) in Economics , University of Delhi	2016
Biosecurity course , BlueDot Impact (in progress)	2026

Selected publications and policy writing

- *The Socioeconomic Impact of Digital Public Infrastructure: Evidence from Bangladesh, Benin, and Ethiopia*. Global Development Network report, 2025.
- “Routine childhood vaccination in India from 2005–2006 to 2015–2016: Temporal trends and geographic variation” (with R. Nayar, N. Mantha, S. Debnath and S. Deo). *Vaccine* 40(48), 2022.
- “COVID-19 Led Return to Kerala: A Comparative Analysis of Return Emigrants” (with S. Irudaya Rajan). *Indian Journal of Labour Economics* 67, 2024.
- “The Last Straw? Experiences and Future Plans of Returned Migrants in the India–GCC Corridor” (with S. Irudaya Rajan and H. Tohidimehr). *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies* 49(20), 2023.
- “Distress Return Migration amidst COVID-19: The Kerala Response” (with S. Irudaya Rajan). *Asian and Pacific Migration Journal* 31(2), 2022.
- “Kerala Return Emigrant Survey 2021: Insights and the Way Forward” and “The resilient international migrant deserves better” (with S. Irudaya Rajan). World Bank Blogs, 2021 and 2020.
- Four book chapters on migration (Routledge, 2020 and 2022; Emerald, 2023; Palgrave, forthcoming) and CDS Working Paper 504 (2021).

Surveys, skills and other

Surveys. Kerala Migration Panel (paper, 15,000 households, 2018); Indian public health worker survey (tablet, 1,200 respondents, 2019); COVID-19 return emigrant survey for the Kerala and Tamil Nadu governments (telephone, 2,500 households, 2021); DPI inclusion survey (five countries, 2026).

Methods and software. Impact evaluation (randomised trials, matching, panel methods), cost modelling, survey and sample design; Stata, R, Python, $\text{\LaTeX}$.

Teaching. Instructor, Smith College (2024–present); lecturer and module lead, International Institute of Migration and Development (2022–present).

Awards. St. Gallen Symposium Leader of Tomorrow (2017); runner-up, Global Migration Award for best master’s thesis in migration (2018).

Languages. Malayalam (native), English (fluent), Hindi (conversational), French (beginner).

Status. Indian citizen; Swiss B permit with the right to work.